



Xerxes crossed the Hellespont as part of his Persian campaign to Greece in 480 BCE. The Hellespont was a narrow sea channel that had been both a frontier and pivotal point of empires. A boundary separating Europe and Asia, it was also a conduit of goods and communication between East and West.



Hatra was a rich trading city in territory disputed between Rome and Parthia (see pp.122–23) between 150 BCE and 224 CE. At times, it was one of several prominent semi-independent or client states (such as Commagene) between the great Roman and Parthian empires. Hatra's circular layout reflected Parthian city patterns, while the architecture revealed Roman influence.



This Greek depiction of northern nomads, known as the Scythians (see pp.138–39), demonstrates trading contact at the meeting point between settled and nomadic worlds. The Scythians were a group of related tribes sharing a common culture and related languages, who spanned the steppe lands from Siberia to southeast Europe.

BEFORE

The natural geographical zones of Eurasia have shaped the growth of powers, their conflicts, and their contacts. In many ways, Mesopotamia remained the heart of the ancient civilized world.

VALLEYS AND SETTLEMENT

Settled urban life began in the fertile valleys and floodplains of **Egypt** << 56–57, **Mesopotamia** << 44–45, and the **Indus** << 58–59. These valleys became central to growing states during the period 3000–1000 BCE.

EXPANDING POWERS

Between 1550 and 700 BCE, the rich, ambitious monarchies of **Egypt** << 64–65 and **Assyria** << 80–81 expanded beyond their valleys into the disputed territory of the **Levant**—the area at the eastern end of the Mediterranean, roughly from modern Turkey south to the Sinai Peninsula. This was a **fertile commercial crossroads** and a gateway to the resources of the Mediterranean.

WORLD DOMINANCE

The Assyrians' heartland lay in the upper part of Mesopotamia, but in c. 800 BCE they **dominated their neighbors** more than any state had done before. They fought the mountain tribes to the

north and east of their realm, but also developed diplomatic relations with them. The Assyrian Empire at last fell to the Babylonians in c. 612 BCE. **Babylon was now at the center of the world** again.



ISHTAR GATE, BABYLON

DESERTS AND FRONTIERS

In the second half of the 1st millennium BCE, the world's great powers became yet more mobile and ambitious. Peoples with roots as horsemen of the steppes, such as the **Persians** 92–93 >>, combined rule of Mesopotamia with expansion from the **Iranian Plateau** to the desert of **Central Asia**. The same heritage of steppe horsemanship brought new military tactics to the **Chinese warring states** in 1000–500 BCE and, later, aided their unification **126–27 >>**.



Dura Europos was founded c. 303 BCE during Greek rule of Mesopotamia, on a trade route on the Euphrates River. The city then came under Parthian, Roman, and then Persian control. Its cultural diversity is reflected in its religious buildings, which include both the earliest preserved synagogue and this church.



Bisitun was a sacred mountain beside a site used successively as a staging post, garden, and palatial retreat. The mountain towered over the route from Babylon, on the low Mesopotamian plain, to the Iranian Plateau. In c. 515 BCE, Persian emperor Darius I (see pp.92–93) carved a monumental relief with an imperial inscription (below) proclaiming his sovereignty over both plateau and plain.



The Indus River was a central link in the route between the Persian Gulf and the interiors of India and Central Asia. The Indus Valley was also a contested frontier between powers including the Achaemenid Persian (see pp.92–93), Seleucid Greek (see pp.98–99), and Mauryan Indian (see pp.124–25) empires.



Kushan statues such as this are relics of a tribal power that in 1–250 CE consolidated a huge land empire between the Hindu Kush mountains and the Ganges River. Known to both Roman and Chinese imperial powers, the Kushans (see pp.138–39) formed a crucial zone of cultural exchange.